

Building Performance Contracting Raises the Bar

The Building Performance Institute, Incorporated (BPI), is providing its accredited contractors and certified professionals with new opportunities to distinguish themselves from their competition in the building performance marketplace. BPI now has 2,500 professionals who have been certified in at least 26 different states; 150 organizations have achieved BPI accreditation. We expect these numbers to increase in response to the new services that BPI is in the midst of launching nationally (see "Double the Services").

BPI now offers three professional certification tracks: Evaluation, Mechanical, and Envelope. Each of these tracks requires a core understanding of building science; to earn a credential, the professional must pass both a written and practical examination in his or her specialty area.

Anyone involved in upgrading the performance of a home can achieve professional certification from BPI. A remodeler, for example, may choose to become a BPI Certified Evaluation professional. The skills provided by this

certification will enable remodelers to expand their business models to include whole building performance assessment and upgrades. Some certified contractors are taking this expansion one step further, moving out of their existing trades and concentrating their business strictly on home performance upgrades.

An HVAC professional with a BPI Certified Mechanical designation will have the skills to help customers understand the interaction between mechanical system performance and other factors—insulation levels, window quality, and air infiltration, for example—that affect the comfort and energy performance of the home. This certification also enables HVAC professionals to identify safety issues that need to be corrected. Certified individuals may still perform only their specialty services, but they can help their customers understand what other work needs to be done to improve the comfort, safety, and performance of a home. Other industry professionals such as weatherization staff, HERS raters, and home inspectors can also benefit from obtaining a BPI certification and being able to expand the range of services they can offer.

Expanding services often means a contractor is taking on bigger jobs with bigger budgets, and BPI stands ready to make financing these bigger jobs a whole lot easier. BPI can now offer accredited contractors financing at attractive rates so that customers can complete comprehensive packages of home performance work.

BPI is also eager to help accredited contractors and organizations get their messages out to consumers. BPI has been developing new marketing and promotional materials that will assist BPI Certified professionals and BPI Accredited organizations in their outreach and education efforts. If you are seeking to enhance your building performance credentials, you should investigate becoming certified. Similarly, businesses looking to truly distinguish themselves from their competition in the home performance marketplace should earn BPI accreditation and participate in the BPI Quality Assurance System.

We at BPI are always interested in refining and improving the services we offer. To that end, we have an ongoing BPI Technical Committee that is open to industry participation. The committee meets twice each year for three days to discuss the development of BPI Technical Standards, professional certification, accreditation of organizations, and the BPI Quality Assurance System. In addition, this group develops and reviews the examination statistics and test items. Subject matter experts from all aspects of building performance are encouraged to take an active role in the BPI Technical Committee.



—Larry Zarker

Larry Zarker is director of national development for the Building Performance Institute, which is located in Malta, New York.

Double the Services

The Building Performance Institute, Incorporated (BPI) and Residential Energy Services Network (RESNET) announced a partnership late last year to improve and expand both organizations' capabilities nationally. The RESNET rater network is now being recognized by BPI as a national quality assurance provider of services for BPI. This will afford BPI an opportunity to promote and service its growing network of BPI Accredited organizations across the country. In addition to quality assurance, the RESNET professional who achieves dual certification through both organizations will now be positioned to provide more comprehensive building evaluation services to both the new and existing housing markets.

RESNET professionals will have the opportunity to earn the new BPI Evalua-

tion professional certification credential with one less requirement than is ordinarily needed, as BPI has determined that certified HERS raters have demonstrated a competency that qualifies them for a waiver of the BPI core examination. Once dual certified, this professional may be able to provide quality assurance services to BPI after meeting a minimal amount of additional requirements. Providing quality assurance services for BPI will help their network while also providing a new business growth opportunity for the HERS rater, according to Steve Baden, executive director of RESNET. Other dual certifications are in the works. "In the future we expect to announce a comprehensive building performance professional certification credential supported by both organizations," says Baden.

FOR MORE INFORMATION:

For more information on BPI certification, accreditation, quality assurance, or the BPI Technical Committee, visit the recently revised BPI Web site at www.bpi.org or call (877)274-1274.